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Date time: March 9th at 12:00

Presenter: Namrata Barve

Presentation Name: None

Summary

Namrata Barve has worked for Garmin for 17 years and her speech focuses on how to climb positions inside a company. She also talks about the transition from school to the fast-paced tech industry. She joined Garmin in 2009 after getting her master's from KU.

She starts her presentation by talking about Garmin's value-based culture, which prioritizes customer service and collaborative effort over the "toxic egos" often found in high-pressure environments. A significant advantage of working at such a diverse company is internal mobility. Namrata was able to transition between different business segments giving her career refreshment without having to move or familiarize herself with a new company.

One of the most important things she talks about is how industry involves high-stakes collaboration, unlike academics. In a professional setting, making code "work" is not enough. The code needs to be maintainable and readable for the entire team. This is made easier because of peer reviews. At the start of her career, she used to get heavy feedback (like 50 comments on a pull request) which helped her learn. Beyond basic coding, engineers also have to learn version control, automated testing, and the art of estimation. As an engineer advances, their role shifts from writing code to guiding others, attending meetings, and solving problems instead of just technical output.

This helped explain why professional growth and promotion is more than just technical abilities. Namrata explained that for one to get promoted, they must have emotional intelligence, initiative, and soft skills. Promotion is rarely a reward for just completing assigned tasks. To become a senior engineer, employees must act like one by taking responsibility for the health of a codebase before they are promoted. For those moving into management, the role becomes focused on making the team shine. Managers must balance the individual strengths of their team members with "stretch" goals that encourage growth. This requires a high degree of self-awareness and the ability to foster trust while navigating different cultural perspectives.

To end the presentation, Namrata talks about the importance of cultural adaptation and self-advocacy. She talks about what it is like being an immigrant woman in a male dominated field. She also shared her experience moving from India to Singapore and then to the United States. One example given was professional norms like punctuality and direct communication being different in each of the three places but still very important.

What I learnt

One of the most important parts of the presentation for me was the transition from university to industry. It involves a fundamental shift in how one approaches technical work. While academic projects often focus on reaching a functional outcome by a deadline, professional engineering requires a focus on long-term maintainability and collaboration. Code is no longer a solo endeavor; it is a shared asset that must be readable and documented so that others can build upon it years later. This is why extensive feedback during peer reviews should be viewed as a valuable mentorship opportunity rather than a personal critique. Mastering tools like version control and understanding the reasoning behind architectural decisions are important steps in becoming a reliable contributor within a team environment.

Another important piece of information is that technical skills aren't enough to get promoted. Professional success depends on communication and emotional intelligence. As an engineer advances, the job goes from writing code to solving business problems. This means adjusting requirements to find the most efficient solution with the least amount of technical debt. Promotion is rarely a reward for simply following orders but is granted to those who already demonstrate senior-level leadership and mentorship.

What I will do diff

Moving forward, I will prioritize problem-solving over simply writing lines of code. At my job, I will think about why each Jira ticket was made and why the solution was suggested so that I can learn about how to come up with my own solutions. I will also look at peer reviews as an opportunity to do better. The critical feedback will be used to accelerate my growth and so I will treat every comment as a mentorship moment. I will also take full ownership of my career by initiating regular conversations with my manager about my goals rather than waiting for direction. By acting with the initiative and accountability of a senior engineer now, I can be better prepared and more likely to get a promotion.